Trellis (working codename)

Feasibility Study

Problem validation · market sizing · comparables · monetization · growth scenarios

Working codename: Trellis · Owner: Syed Hassaan Saleem · Version 0.1 · Status: Draft · July 2026 · Companion to Product Charter & PRD v0.3

> *Scope note: this study tests whether the problem defined in the PRD is real and monetizable, how large the opportunity is, and how far the business can plausibly grow. Figures are directional ranges synthesized from 2025–2026 public sources (bracketed numbers reference Section 10) and should be spot-checked before external use.*

1. Executive verdict

Conditionally feasible — proceed to field validation. The two demand-side assumptions behind Trellis are now supported by independent 2025–2026 data: travelers are adopting AI planning at one of the fastest rates the industry has recorded, yet demand for human-accountable advisors is rising, not falling — including among the youngest, most AI-fluent travelers. On the supply side, agents demonstrably pay for tooling and access (Fora), pay for qualified leads (Zicasso), and are being courted by converging B2B entrants (kimkim, Mindtrip). The transaction pools Trellis monetizes are large: US$200B+ in hotel wholesale, ~US$89B in multi-day tours, and an online travel booking market heading past US$1 trillion.

Two findings require changes to the current plan. First, the proposed monetization mix (agent lead fees, white-label fees, B2B promotions and ads; travelers free) is validated in principle but mis-sequenced: leads and advertising only produce revenue once consumer traffic exists, which is Phase 2 of the roadmap. Booking margin, marketplace take-rate and light SaaS must carry P0–P1. Second, adjacent funded players are converging on the same square; the defensible asset is marketplace liquidity in a beachhead niche, and speed to that liquidity matters more than breadth.

2. Is the problem real?

2.1 Traveler side

- **AI planning adoption is fast and accelerating.** 56% of US leisure travelers used AI for at least one trip as of early 2026, up from 43% roughly nine months earlier [1]. A global Kantar survey puts AI-assisted trip planning at ~40% of consumers [3].
- **The awareness-to-booking gap is the product opportunity.** ~90% of travelers know AI can plan trips but only ~38% have tried it; among users, 78% have booked travel based primarily on an AI recommendation [2]. The blocker is confidence that the plan holds up against real prices and real inventory — precisely the budget-aware, live-priced planner Trellis specifies.
- **Human-accountable demand is growing, led by the young.** 60% of Gen Z and Millennial travelers say they want to use a travel advisor, citing deals, high-demand periods and planning complexity (Chase Travel survey of 4,000+ travelers) [4]. Among AI users, 51% of Gen Z/Millennials have used an advisor — the highest of any generation — and prefer one for trip failures, complex multi-destination trips, groups and luxury [5].

> *Implication: AI usage and advisor usage are complements, not substitutes. This directly validates the PRD's self-drive vs. request-an-agent fork and the ~8% AI-booking trust ceiling (Expedia/YouGov, 2026) already cited in Section 7d of the PRD.*

2.2 Agent side

- **Agents pay for tooling + access at scale.** Fora: 15,000+ advisors, US$2.5B booked since 2021 across 180+ countries, on a US$99/quarter or US$299/year membership; advisors reach seven-figure books of business in an average of 20 months versus a three-year industry norm [6][7][8].
- **The friction is documented by incumbents themselves.** Fora's own investment thesis: travel is a ~US$1.8T market in which advisors deliver under 10% of hotel bookings, and booking through an advisor remains slow, offline and opaque [6].
- **Supply for a resale marketplace exists and is fragmented.** Arival counts ~10,000 multi-day tour operators worldwide — three in five of them small businesses — with ~US$89B in pre-pandemic gross sales and 26.6% annual booking growth in recent years [9][10]. Thousands of small sellers hold destination expertise with no liquid, self-serve resale channel.
- **The market is converging on the thesis.** kimkim, after a decade selling local-specialist trips to consumers, launched a travel-advisor B2B platform in late 2025 through which advisors request fully built, priced itineraries from destination specialists [11][12] — agent-to-agent trade arriving from the consumer direction. Mindtrip acquired the creator-itinerary marketplace Thatch in March 2025 [13].

Founder-market fit is a supporting signal (the owner has personally experienced the traveler-side problem), but the study treats third-party evidence as primary.

3. Market size — layered

Trellis monetizes several distinct layers; a single TAM figure would be misleading. Sizing each layer separately:

Layer	Size & trajectory	Relevance to Trellis
Global travel market	~US$1.8T [6]	Context only
Online travel bookings	US$519B (2023) → US$1T+ by 2032, ~8% CAGR [14]	The GBV pool the North Star metric draws from
Hotel wholesale / bedbank channel	~US$147B (2018) → ~US$211B projected 2026 [15]; wholesale ≈ 8–9% of hotel TTV [16]	Pillar 2 supply; the structural margin pool
Multi-day / packaged tours	~US$89B gross sales across ~10,000 operators; 26.6% recent annual growth [9][10]	Pillar 3's tradeable asset class
Tours & activities reservations	~US$173B (2024), 7.5% CAGR [17]	Attach / commission layer
Travel agency software (SaaS)	~US$1.2B (2024) → US$2.3B by 2032 [18]; some analysts up to US$6.8B → US$15.2B by 2033 [19]	Pillar 1's honest ceiling — small; the wedge, not the business
Generative AI in travel	~US$1.1B (2025) → ~US$5.8B by 2035, 18.6% CAGR [20]	Tailwind / narrative, not direct revenue
Travel commerce media (ads)	Sits inside ~US$50B US retail media (2023) [21]; Expedia:	Late-stage revenue layer (What's Hot promotions)

	US$197M ad revenue in Q1 2026 alone [22]	

> *Strategic takeaway: the SaaS tool market is a ~US$1–5B pond; the transaction layers are US$200B+ pools. Monetizing flows (margin, take-rate, leads, promotions) rather than seat licenses is directionally correct — consistent with the PRD's "come for the tool, stay for the network" sequencing.*

A wholesale-economics detail for the unit model: hotels typically cede ~25% of consumer price to wholesale channels, split roughly two-thirds to the travel seller and one-third to the wholesaler [16]. This is the pool the markup engine and marketplace take-rate carve from — structural margin, invisible to the traveler.

4. Comparables & case studies

Fora Travel — proves agents pay and the model scales. Founded 2021; US$78.2M raised (Thrive Capital, Insight Partners, Forerunner); 15,000+ advisors; US$2.5B booked; named to TIME's 100 Most Influential Companies, April 2026 [7]. 97% of its advisors are new to selling travel — the tooling created a new supply base rather than merely serving the existing one [7]. **Warning embedded:** Fora is a closed host-agency umbrella; the open peer-to-peer marketplace is Trellis's differentiated axis, but Fora's war chest means "Fora but open" cannot be executed slowly.

Thatch → Mindtrip — proves itinerary commerce; warns on standalone scale. Thatch built the marketplace for creator guides and planning services (sellers keeping ~90%), raised a US$3M seed in 2021, and was acquired by Mindtrip in March 2025, with its community folded into Mindtrip's creator program [13]. Consumer guide margins were too thin to reach escape velocity — supporting Trellis's choice of professional B2B2B resale on net rates rather than low-ticket consumer guides. Mindtrip's own cadence (US$7M seed 2023; US$12M Sept 2024; further funding, a B2B product, then the Thatch acquisition within roughly six months) illustrates competitor velocity [23].

Zicasso — validates charging agents for leads. For over a decade Zicasso has delivered pre-qualified luxury trip leads (traveler profile, style, budget) to a vetted network of specialists at no upfront charge — agents pay only when a lead converts to a sale [24]. This is the exact mechanism for Trellis's consumer→agent handoff fee; pay-on-conversion also solves cold-start trust better than pay-per-lead.

kimkim — validates the take-rate and signals convergence. kimkim connects travelers to vetted local specialists, taking ~15% of specialist profit [25]; consumer trust is real (19,600+ reviews at 4.8/5) [26]. Its late-2025 launch of a travel-advisor platform — advisors submit trip requests and receive fully built, priced itineraries from destination specialists, with commission incentives [11][12] — is agent-to-agent trade approaching from the opposite direction. The B2B2B window is open but will not stay open indefinitely.

Advertising benchmarks — validate the ads model at scale, and only at scale. Expedia Group generated US$197M from EG Advertising in Q1 2026 (+13% YoY) plus US$125M from trivago, with advertising & media at 9% of total revenue [22]; Uber's media network generates ~US$1B [27]. These businesses ride on hundreds of millions of visitors — a Year-3-to-5 stream for Trellis, not a foundation.

5. Monetization model — assessment

Proposed model under review: charge agents for leads, white-labels, and B2B promotions in the What's Hot feed (eSIM, hotels, airlines) plus advertising; never charge travelers.

- **Travelers free — correct.** No consumer planner wins on subscription. One precision matters: booking margin is not "charging users." Markup on net rates and attach commissions are invisible to the traveler; forgoing them would abandon the largest proven pool in the stack. Keep them.
- **Lead / handoff fees — validated (Zicasso, kimkim) but P2 revenue.** They require consumer demand that, per the roadmap, does not exist until the consumer surface launches.
- **What's Hot promotions & ads — validated at scale, premature at launch.** Sponsored placement must also respect the feed's own hard rule (every item actionable, trustworthy, clearly labeled) or it poisons the feed's credibility. Supplier brand budgets arrive only with demonstrable audience.
- **White-label fees — sound**, as a premium tier on marketplace resale terms.

Recommended revenue sequencing (restores the PRD's original stack for the early phases; adds the new streams where they become real):

Phase	Revenue streams live	Rationale
P0–P1	Booking margin on net rates + marketplace take-rate + light SaaS membership (Fora proves US$299/yr clears; a Zicasso-style pay-on-transaction variant lowers the barrier further)	Revenue from the first booked trip; pressure-tests whether agents value the platform; funds the liquidity race
P2	Add consumer→agent handoff fees (pay-on-conversion) + ancillaries (eSIM, insurance)	Consumer surface now generates qualified demand; ancillaries attach to booked trips
P3	Add What's Hot sponsored placements / travel media network (labeled), supplier promotions	Requires audience scale; high-margin layer on top of transactions, per Expedia/Uber precedent [22][27]

> *Risk if unsequenced: dropping SaaS and take-rate in favor of leads + ads implies near-zero revenue for 18–24 months and no monetization signal from the agent side — the side whose willingness to pay is the entire wedge.*

6. How large can this get — bottom-up scenarios

Anchor comparable: Fora's 15K advisors → US$2.5B cumulative in ~4.5 years implies roughly US$150–200K booked per advisor over their platform lifetime, with a steep power curve (a minority of advisors drive most volume) [7]. Scenarios below assume Trellis captures a partial share of wallet per agent and a blended monetization of 3–7% across markup share, take-rate and fees.

Stage	Key assumptions	GBV	Indicative revenue
P0–P1 (18–24 months, 1–2 niches)	500–1,000 active agents · US$30–80K GBV per agent/yr through the platform	US$25–80M	US$1–5M
P2 (consumer surface live)	3,000–5,000 agents · consumer handoffs beginning · ancillary attach	US$200–500M	US$10–30M

Category leadership ceiling	10–15K agents (Fora-scale participation) · deeper share of wallet · consumer demand at scale	US$1.5–3B / yr	US$50–150M + media layer

Against an online-travel GBV pool exceeding US$500B and growing [14], the ceiling is set by execution and liquidity, not market size. The single number that determines viability is **blended take per trip vs. two-sided CAC** — already flagged as an open question in PRD Section 15; the field plan in Section 9 is designed to produce it.

7. Strategic position — why Trellis can win

The focus thesis, stated precisely: OTAs (Booking.com globally; Sastaticket and peers regionally) compete on **inventory depth and price on the booking/search axis** and are structurally disincentivized to build a neutral agent workflow and peer-resale network — it would cannibalize their direct consumer relationship, and agents are a cost channel or competitor to them. Bedbanks own inventory but no workflow or client experience. Consumer AI planners own UX but lack supply economics and human accountability. Trellis builds the layer that **consumes** their inventory and adds what none of them will: professional workflow, the tradeable itinerary as an asset class, and an accountable human in the loop. Complementary to inventory — the position where startups survive next to giants.

> *Honest counterweight: focus is a strategy input, not a moat. The moat, if earned, is (a) B2B2B liquidity — finished itineraries listed and actually reselling; (b) workflow lock-in — agents whose bookings, clients and commissions live in Trellis; (c) the compounding corpus of structured, vetted, priced itineraries that no one else is accumulating. Mindtrip buying Thatch, kimkim entering B2B, and Fora's US$78M all indicate convergence — speed to liquidity in one beachhead beats elegance of positioning.*

8. Feasibility-specific risks

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Revenue mis-sequencing (leads/ads before audience exists)	High	Adopt the P0–P3 revenue stack in Section 5; monetize agent transactions from day one
Liquidity race vs. converging funded players (Fora, Mindtrip, kimkim)	High	Single beachhead niche; seed with power-seller agencies; concierge-broker early resales manually
Resale reluctance (specialists won't sell to potential competitors)	Med–High	Test white-label + client-ownership terms with real agents before build (Section 9)
Ads compromise feed trust	Medium	Labeled sponsorship only; enforce the "every item actionable" rule on paid placements
Market-size figures are vendor estimates with wide variance	Medium	Ranges used throughout; spot-check before investor use (per PRD footnote practice)

9. Field validation plan (pre-build)

- **Agent interviews (n = 15–20)**, split between solo/small agencies and specialist/DMC agents. Test the riskiest assumption directly: will specialists resell to potential competitors under white-label and client-ownership terms — and at what revenue-share percentages? Capture indicative yes/no at specific numbers, not sentiment.
- **Concierge MVP**: manually broker 10–20 itinerary resales between real agents before writing marketplace code. Yields actual take-rate tolerance, channel-conflict behavior, and the first resold:self-built data point.
- **Two-sided smoke test**: landing pages + waitlists for agents and travelers to produce a first CAC signal on each side.
- **Beachhead hypothesis to test**: Pakistan/GCC outbound corridors (Umrah and religious travel especially) are packaged-travel-heavy, served by thousands of small agents with thin tooling, and largely ignored by the Western tools in the PRD's competitive table — while regional OTAs concentrate on flights. Potentially winnable first liquidity from the founder's home market; a hypothesis to validate, not a conclusion.
- **Unit-economics worksheet**: blended take per trip vs. CAC per side, using the wholesale split in Section 3 and interview-derived take-rates.

10. Sources

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[16] Third Bridge Forum interview — wholesale ≈ 8–9% of hotel TTV; ~25% wholesale commission split ~2/3 seller, 1/3 wholesaler. thirdbridge.com

[17] GII Research, Tours & Activities Reservations Market — US$173B (2024), 7.5% CAGR. giiresearch.com

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[21] Advertiser Perceptions via Marketing Dive — US retail media ad spend ~US$50B (2023). marketingdive.com

[22] Expedia Group Form 10-Q, Q1 2026 (SEC) — US$197M EG Advertising (+13% YoY) + US$125M trivago; advertising & media 9% of revenue. sec.gov

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[27] PhocusWire (Oct 2024) — travel commerce media; Uber ~US$1B media network. phocuswire.com

> *Market and margin figures are directional ranges synthesized from 2025–2026 industry sources and vary by scope, market, and negotiated terms. Comparable-company figures reflect public reporting and should be re-verified before external use. "Trellis" remains a placeholder pending trademark/domain clearance.*